



feminine and oscillates between playing a woman reclining in a red leather sofa, to a fashion model and a saree-clad siren—is any indication, audiences are definitely lapping up his photo-realistic works.

"The point to really look out for is how well the artist has used his own portrait in the scheme of his visual language. Is the artist's compulsion narcissist and shallow or does it serve a greater purpose in the content of the painting?" says Varma. "In Upadhyay's works, there is a subtlety. You never feel you are staring at the artist. Her self-portrayal serves a purpose in the overall idea of the painting. When used well, I don't see why anybody should mind owning a work with the artist's image," she adds.

I, ME, MYSELF: Self-referenced works by Karmakar (left) and Kallat

desires in perspective in my paintings and become a performing artist," he says. His exhibition *Funtitled*, which was exhibited at Arndean Gallery, London, in March, and his recent display at Mumbai's Lansdowne Gallery, part of a group show *Cool 5*, saw Kapse's own visage painted on his canvases. His creations are an irreverent, mocking display as he plays the bespectacled body-builder and jokester.

While self-portraiture, by its very nature, alludes to narcissism and vanity, Pushpamala has in the past shrugged off accusations of self-adulation: "I am performing as a part of a photo-performance. By being in the frame I'm implicating myself, I become a part of the interpretation." Similarly, Dodiya finds her language in her self, which remains a constant theme in her works. Shireen Gandhi of Chemould Prescott Road, a contemporary art gallery, says it is her consistent motif. "Dodiya's thought process begins with the self. Her portraits are not about a reflection of her persona, but her self becomes a conduit of expressions and gestures of historical references," she says.

And while Gogh's mug might add to your equity and a Sher-Gill might plump up your portfolio, can self-images of newbies find any willing takers? Kallat, whose artworks



between 1993 and 1999 were often "anchored in the self", believes that audiences were never averse to seeing self-image in art. Gandhi says, "With Pushpamala, there was always an audience that appreciated and enjoyed the work, but sales were slow. Now, it is difficult to get hold of her work as her editions have almost sold out." The artist has now extended her photo-performances to films, where she builds the narrative through photographs and extends it into the film.

And if the commercial success of Baroda-based artist Karmakar's works—where the artist confronts his androgynous self, questions perceived notions of the masculine and the

Even as artists assert themselves on the canvas, constantly experimenting with video installations and live performance pieces, Kallat is cautious about this new "trend". "I think it is dangerous to make a hasty comment and read it as a trend. The usage of a self-image has to be a result of an internal artistic compulsion rather than an acute scarcity of ideas. I see both varieties in our art world," he adds.

So while "performing on canvas" may not exactly be playing to the gallery, artists are certainly showing an openness to experimentation—a heartening sign in a commerce-driven creative sphere where artistry constantly competes with asset value. ■